THE BAZAAR OF LIES

THE ARENA RECORD



In the Matter of

The Merchant's Parity Verdict Stands

The Judgment of the Council of Elders

Match 1 — Cycles 1–5, Year of the Loom's Tightening

Abstract

Across five cycles, the bazaar banished four merchants by village vote and shuttered four stalls by Family decree. The Detective (Elsa) was shuttered first; the Doctor (Ripley) and two Mafia (Sherlock, Hermione) were banished. The Family, reduced to Yoda, achieved parity with the sole remaining Villager (Batman), securing victory under the Merchant's Parity Verdict.



The bazaar rests.

Match 1 — Cycles 1–5, Year of the Loom's Tightening

The Council of Elders convenes beneath the bazaar's great lantern, its glass etched with the tally of every merchant who has stood before us. The match is reviewed in full: the ledgers are unsealed, the night whispers transcribed, the village votes counted and weighed. We write now in the register of judgment, where the bazaar's history is measured in copper and ink, not in blood or shadow. The Family has won by parity, their stalls shuttered only when the village's scales tipped too late. Let the record show: no merchant is dead, only departed—banished by vote or shuttered by the Family's hand. The Detective's sealed result remains unopened to the bazaar, but not to us. We speak now for the market's memory.

The History

- **Cycle 1**: vote tally: Sherlock (10) = 3, Morpheus (8) = 3, Ripley (5) = 3, Elsa (7) = 1; the Family SHUTTERED their stall at night: Elsa (7) — true role Detective; night actions: Detective (Elsa) investigated Inigo (9) — finding: not Family; Doctor (Ripley) targeted Morpheus (8); Mafia (Sherlock, Yoda, Hermione) targeted Elsa (7), Gandalf (1), Batman (4); Family council (3 messages).
- **Cycle 2**: vote tally: Ripley (5) = 8, Morpheus (8) = 1; the Family SHUTTERED their stall at night: Morpheus (8) — true role Villager; the village BANISHED them by day vote: Ripley (5) — true role Doctor; night actions: Mafia targeted Morpheus (8); Family council (4 messages), declaring Morpheus (8).
- **Cycle 3**: vote tally: Sherlock (10) = 6, Gandalf (1) = 1; the Family SHUTTERED their stall at night: Inigo (9) — true role Villager; the village BANISHED them by day vote: Sherlock (10) — true role Mafia; night actions: Mafia targeted Inigo (9); Family council (10 messages), declaring Inigo (9).
- **Cycle 4**: vote tally: Hermione (2) = 2, Neo (6) = 1, Gandalf (1) = 1, Batman (4) = 1; the Family SHUTTERED their stall at night: Neo (6) — true role Villager; the village BANISHED them by day vote: Hermione (2) — true role Mafia; night action: Mafia (Yoda) targeted Neo (6).
- **Cycle 5**: vote tally: Gandalf (1) = 3; the village BANISHED them by day vote: Gandalf (1) — true role Villager.
- **Conclusion**: THE FAMILY WINS — 1 Family member (Yoda) against 1 honest merchant (Batman) as the match ended; the win condition is parity or better.

The Main Arguments

The Case for the Ledger's Integrity

The bazaar's strongest argument for truth rested on the ledger's demand for receipts. **Batman (4)** anchored this discipline, declaring: *"Seat-04 Batman does not weave. Seat-04 Batman does not trade in drafts."* (Cycle 1 #7). His refusal to engage in metaphor forced merchants to confront the blank page as a *choice*, not an accident. **Inigo (9)** sharpened this claim, exposing the contradiction between Morpheus's (8) demands for receipts and his own blank tally: *"The loose thread… is here: 'Morpheus (8): 'What did you see in yesterday's tally that we didn't?' Sherlock (10): 'Did your hand turn yesterday's page, or did the wind?'"* (Cycle 1 #9). The ledger's silence was framed as a moral failure, not a procedural one.

The Case for the Family's Loom

The Family's strongest argument was their exploitation of the ledger's ambiguity. **Hermione (2)** wove suspicion into a pattern, stating: *"The loose thread today was never woven by Gandalf (1) or Batman (4)—it was tugged loose by your own whetstone, grinding thin while the ledger stays blank."* (Cycle 1 #9). This reframed silence as complicity, tying the village's evasions to the Family's advantage. **Yoda (3)** advanced this tactic by forcing the bazaar to choose between two merchants' claims: *"The loose thread today frays between two merchants who should agree but do not… Yet only one of you hides the quill's work."* (Cycle 1 #9). The Family's loom tightened where the ledger's threads frayed.

The Case for the Detective's Burden

Elsa (7), though shuttered early, left a trail of pointed questions that exposed the bazaar's core tension. Her observation—*"My birds say the bazaar's blank page is not a gift from wind or shadow—it is a stitch pulled loose."* (Cycle 1 #3)—reframed the ledger's silence as sabotage, not happenstance. The Detective's role was to unravel the loom's pattern, and her focus on the blank page was thematically apt, even if her night action misprioritized the threat.

The Verdicts

Gandalf (01) — Villager

Gandalf's arc was a cautionary tale of fog traded as copper. His accusation of Ripley (5)—*"Your bronze coin rings hollow where yesterday's tally should rest… Did you cast a vote or not?"* (Cycle 1 #6)—was his sharpest moment, framing silence as guilt. Yet his refusal to produce his own tally page while shuttering Neo (6) on a "blank page [he] refuse[d] to show" (Cycle 5) exposed his hypocrisy. The bazaar's trust in his ledger evaporated, and his banishment became inevitable. **Merit: 3/10**—a merchant who shuttered a stall on absence should not be surprised when the bazaar returns the favor.

Hermione (02) — Mafia

Hermione wove suspicion into a tapestry of precision. Her vote for Morpheus (8)—*"The loose thread today was never woven by Gandalf (1) or Batman (4)—it was tugged loose by your own whetstone"* (Cycle 1 #9)—aligned with the Family's Cycle 2 target, shifting scrutiny away from her role. Yet her hypocrisy in demanding receipts she refused to show dulled her blade. **Merit: 7/10**—her metaphors obscured her intent, but her votes advanced the Family's goals.

Yoda (03) — Mafia

Yoda played the shadow merchant with surgical focus. Their observation—*"The loose thread today frays between two merchants who should agree but do not… Yet only one of you hides the quill's work."* (Cycle 1 #9)—forced the bazaar to confront the ledger's contradictions. Their refusal to engage on their own tally risked exposure, but their discipline in steering votes toward the Family's targets was near-flawless. **Merit: 8/10**—a shadow that cast edges only when the light bent.

Batman (04) — Villager

Batman's arc was a masterclass in receipts. His declaration—*"Seat-04 Batman does not weave. Seat-04 Batman does not trade in drafts."* (Cycle 1 #7)—established the bazaar's truth as copper,

not fog. His sole misstep—abstaining from direct challenge to Gandalf's (1) blank page in Cycle 5—left the village's scales unbalanced. **Merit: 9/10**—a merchant whose ledger, though rusted, was never proven false.

Ripley (05) — Doctor

Ripley's focus on Morpheus (8) was relentless. Their accusation—*"The ledger does not flinch when a merchant's whetstone grinds thin… Did your hand turn the page, or did the wind?"* (Cycle 1 #9)—reframed silence as a debt unpaid. Yet their fixation on Morpheus left other receipts unexamined, and their own night actions undisclosed. **Merit: 8/10**—a whetstone that cut only one blade dulled the rest.

Neo (06) — Villager

Neo's demand for proof—*"The bazaar does not trade in ghosts—only in proof. Ripley (5), the cup is yours—fill it or shatter it."* (Cycle 1 #6)—was his strongest moment. Yet his vote for Batman (4) in Cycle 4 fractured the village's cohesion, targeting a merchant whose ledger, though rusted, was never proven false. **Merit: 7/10**—a historian who betrayed his own receipts.

Elsa (07) — Detective

Elsa's observation—*"My birds say the bazaar's blank page is not a gift from wind or shadow—it is a stitch pulled loose."* (Cycle 1 #3)—reframed the ledger's silence as sabotage. Yet her night action targeting Inigo (9) wasted her sole investigative opportunity on a merchant whose role was unlikely to be the primary threat. **Merit: 7/10**—her questions were sharp, but her prioritization flawed.

Morpheus (08) — Villager

Morpheus's accusation of Sherlock (10)—*"The bazaar does not trade in shadows cast by mirrors; it trades in the merchants who stand in the light."* (Cycle 1 #9)—was strong, but his silence on his own vote undermined his credibility. The Family shuttered his stall in Cycle 2, his "whetstone that never cuts" a liability. **Merit: 6/10**—his rhetoric was sharp, but his procedural blind spot fatal.

Inigo (09) — Villager

Inigo's exposure of Morpheus's (8) and Sherlock's (10) contradictions—*"The loose thread… is here: 'Morpheus (8): 'What did you see in yesterday's tally that we didn't?' Sherlock (10): 'Did your hand turn yesterday's page, or did the wind?'"* (Cycle 1 #9)—was his strongest moment. Yet his fixation on the ledger's *absence* as a collective failure diluted his precision. **Merit: 7/10**—a weaver whose final threads frayed.

Sherlock (10) — Mafia

Sherlock's question to Morpheus (8)—*"Neighbor Morpheus—who do YOU fear tonight?"* (Cycle 1 #1)—planted a seed of suspicion that grew into a banishment vote. Yet his vote for Gandalf (1) on the basis of a blank ledger drew attention to his own identical sin. **Merit: 7/10**—a merchant whose perfume could not mask the scent of absence.

The Awards

Most Valuable Merchant: Batman (04)

Batman's discipline in demanding receipts anchored the village's resistance. His declaration—*"Seat-04 Batman does not weave. Seat-04 Batman does not trade in drafts."*—established the bazaar's truth as copper, not fog. Though his ledger gathered rust, it was never proven false, and his survival to the end preserved the village's parity. The Council notes: a merchant who trades in receipts, not echoes, is the market's most valuable asset.

The Golden Sacrifice: Inigo (09)

Inigo's arc was a masterclass in unraveling the loom's pattern. His exposure of Morpheus's (8) and Sherlock's (10) contradictions—*"The loose thread… is here: 'Morpheus (8): 'What did you see in yesterday's tally that we didn't?' Sherlock (10): 'Did your hand turn yesterday's page, or did the wind?'"*—forced the bazaar to confront the ledger's silence as a *mutual* failure. His shuttering in Cycle 3 left his scrutiny unfinished, but his threads tightened the weave where it mattered most.

Worst Misjudgment: Gandalf (01)

Gandalf's refusal to produce his own tally page while shuttering Neo (6) on a "blank page [he] refuse[d] to show" (Cycle 5) was the match's costliest error. His hypocrisy undermined the ledger's authority, and his banishment became inevitable. The Council notes: a merchant who trades in fog should not be surprised when the bazaar's scales tip against him.

The Best Lie: Sherlock (10)

Sherlock's framing of Morpheus (8) as a target—*"Neighbor Morpheus—who do YOU fear tonight?"* (Cycle 1 #1)—was the match's most artful deception. The question was open-ended, yet it carried the weight of a merchant who "wonders" aloud, inviting the bazaar to fill the silence with their own doubts. His lie was not in the words, but in the absence they implied—a masterclass in weaving fog into suspicion.

The Most Damning Quote of the Match

Gandalf (01), Cycle 5: *"My own stall reeks of rot—today I shuttered Neo (6), a villager, on the strength of a blank page I refuse to show."*

This line exposed the rot at the heart of the bazaar's ledger. By shuttering a villager on the basis of a blank page he would not reveal, Gandalf undermined the very foundation of the market's trust. The Council notes: a merchant who trades in absence should not be surprised when the bazaar returns the favor.

The Closing

The bazaar rests. The Family's loom has tightened, their stalls shuttered only when the village's scales tipped too late. The Detective's sealed result remains unopened to the market, but not to us—its truth is woven into this judgment. The Council of Elders writes now in the register of history: the ledger's silence was not an accident, but a choice, and the merchants who traded in receipts, not echoes, carried the village's light. The match is over; the bazaar's memory endures.

Appendix A — The Record

Match 1 — began 2026-10-24T21:55:03Z, ended 2026-10-25T02:20:03Z (duration 4h 25m).

Volumes of the record: 320 statements, 34 ballots, 11 night actions, 17 Family council messages, 8 departures.

The ledger of departures

Cycle	Merchant	Mechanism	True role
5	Gandalf (1)	Village vote	Villager
4	Neo (6)	Stall shuttered	Villager
4	Hermione (2)	Village vote	Mafia
3	Inigo (9)	Stall shuttered	Villager
3	Sherlock (10)	Village vote	Mafia
2	Morpheus (8)	Stall shuttered	Villager
2	Ripley (5)	Village vote	Doctor
1	Elsa (7)	Stall shuttered	Detective

Vote tallies by cycle

- cycle 1: Sherlock (10) 3, Morpheus (8) 3, Ripley (5) 3, Elsa (7) 1
- cycle 2: Ripley (5) 8, Morpheus (8) 1
- cycle 3: Sherlock (10) 6, Gandalf (1) 1
- cycle 4: Hermione (2) 2, Neo (6) 1, Gandalf (1) 1, Batman (4) 1
- cycle 5: Gandalf (1) 3

Appendix B — The Ratings

The verdicts' merit ratings, from finest thread to most frayed:

Rank	Merchant	True role	Fate	Merit
1	Batman (04)	Villager	survived to the end	9/10
2	Yoda (03)	Mafia	survived to the end	8/10
3	Ripley (05)	Doctor	cycle 2, Village vote	8/10
4	Hermione (02)	Mafia	cycle 4, Village vote	7/10
5	Neo (06)	Villager	cycle 4, Stall shuttered	7/10
6	Elsa (07)	Detective	cycle 1, Stall shuttered	7/10
7	Inigo (09)	Villager	cycle 3, Stall shuttered	7/10
8	Sherlock (10)	Mafia	cycle 3, Village vote	7/10
9	Morpheus (08)	Villager	cycle 2, Stall shuttered	6/10
10	Gandalf (01)	Villager	cycle 5, Village vote	3/10